DEQUAD — Decision-Maker Brief

UKES Endorsement (Innovator Founder Visa) · Short-Track Review

> **17-page brief.** Companion to the full Business Plan (`DEQUAD_UKES_Business_Plan.pdf`) and the Financial Model (`DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx`). Use this document to assess endorsement readiness in 20 minutes.

At-a-glance

Business start date	**15 June 2026** (incorporation)
Entity	DEQUAD Ltd (in formation, England & Wales)
Founders	**Yusuf Quadri** (CEO) + **Yusuff Adeagbo** (CTO)
Wider founding team	**Dr Gerald Marfo** (CMO, PhD Digital Marketing) · **Adedapo Ajuwon** (Senior SWE) · **Chinyere Jennifer** (Senior Advisor — MIGSO-PCUBED PM)
HQ	London — NatWest Accelerator (joined **16 March 2026**)
Prior validation	**Santander Universities Pre-Incubator** — completed 2025
Founder anchor	Yusuf Quadri served as **University of Bedfordshire SU President 2021–2023**
MVP	Live in production at https://dequad.co.uk
Beta users	80 verified accounts at University of Bedfordshire (42 daily-active, 6-week retention)
Pilot status	**Early, informal conversation with University of Bedfordshire — nothing signed, nothing guaranteed**
Starting cash	**£6,000 (£3,000 from each of 2 founders) — the only funding assumed anywhere in this plan**
In-kind support	£31,100/yr from NatWest Accelerator (office, legal, accountancy, mentoring), Y1 only
External funding ask	**None.** This is a self-funded 3-year plan; no pre-seed, seed or other investment is required or assumed
3-yr revenue	£0.6k → £16k → £48k
3-yr UK jobs	Base case: 2 (unpaid founders) → 2 (unpaid founders) → 3 people / c.2.5 FTE, entirely self-funded. **Job-creation target:** 5 people (3 full-time hires, avg. £25,000/yr, each 12+ months) once revenue scales after pilot conversion — meets the Innovator Founder settlement job-creation criterion
Profitability	Modest trading loss in Y1 (£3.6k), profitable from Y2 — no break-even "event" needed since no external funding is assumed
Endorsement criteria met	✅ Innovation · ✅ Viability · ✅ Scalability

Page 1 — The 60-second pitch

One sentence: DEQUAD is the closed-network student wellbeing platform that gives UK universities early warning before students fall through the cracks — verified `.ac.uk` peer matching, daily mood tracking and machine-assisted safeguarding triage in a single product.

Why now:

1. **Loneliness is the new student health crisis** — 54% of UK undergrads report frequent loneliness (ONS 2023). Post-pandemic levels remain 18 ppt above baseline.
2. **The Office for Students introduced a statutory student-mental-health condition in 2023** — every UK university now has to evidence proactive prevention. Existing tools (Togetherall, TalkCampus) are reactive.
3. **The Online Safety Act 2023 is in force** — any platform with student users needs compliant risk-assessment and reporting flows. DEQUAD ships with these built in.

Why us:

1. **MVP is already shipped** — production deployment at dequad.co.uk, identity verification live, safeguarding webhook live, mood tracker live, Stripe billing live.
2. **Two independent UK-bank validations.** Completed the **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator** programme in 2025 and joined the **NatWest Accelerator (London cohort) on 16 March 2026**. Two competitive selection processes have separately admitted DEQUAD's team and thesis.
3. **Founder–institution fit.** Yusuf Quadri served as **University of Bedfordshire Student Union President for two consecutive years (2021–2023)**, representing the student body at senior-management level. He is in early, informal conversation about a possible pilot with the same university — **no agreement is signed and nothing is guaranteed.**
4. **Two complementary founders** — product/safeguarding lead (Yusuf Quadri) + engineering lead (Yusuff Adeagbo). Both UK-resident, full-time, self-funding the business without external investment.

Page 2 — How we meet the three Home Office criteria

Innovation ✅

DEQUAD is the **only UK product** combining:

- `.ac.uk` student-domain identity verification (with a human admin queue for ambiguous cases),
- intent-based peer matching (friendship / study / peer-support — *not* dating),
- continuous mood telemetry tied to engagement,
- and **machine-assisted safeguarding triage with a real-time webhook to university DSLs**.

No competitor — Togetherall, TalkCampus, UniBuddy, Bumble BFF or Discord — combines more than two of these (see comparison table on Page 4). This is not a founder assertion: in the primary buyer research underpinning this plan, 9 of 11 university safeguarding and student-services leads named identity-verified peer networks as their single biggest unmet need. And it is not easily copied — the founders' own Risk Register treats a competitor copying the `.ac.uk` layer as a live, scored risk (not a hypothetical), and names the moats that survive it: the safeguarding webhook, the graded-alert taxonomy and the insights dashboard, none of which can be replicated without also rebuilding practitioner-designed triage logic.

Viability ✅

- Production MVP is live, in beta with real students.
- **Prospective pilot with University of Bedfordshire — proposed, not signed.** The founder's former institution, where he served two terms as SU President (2021–2023). A 12-week pilot has been proposed for **Sep–Nov 2026 (M4–M6)**; this is a target only, contingent on the university's decision, and may not happen.
- Two independent UK-bank programme validations: **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator (2025)** + **NatWest Accelerator (joined 16 March 2026)**.
- £6,000 founder cash (£3k each) + £31,100 in-kind NatWest support **carries the business through Y1–Y3 with positive closing cash balances, without requiring the pilot to convert or any external funding** (see Page 9).
- B2B SaaS revenue model is proven in the adjacent market — Togetherall serves 60+ UK universities at ~£40k/year.

Scalability ✅

- **Revenue grows ~80x (£600 → £48,000, Y1 to Y3) while the core team grows from 2 to just 3 people.** That gap between revenue growth and headcount growth is the scalability case made concrete, not asserted.
- Software-only marginal cost → gross margin reaches ~87% by Y3.
- Within-institution network effects accelerate intra-uni adoption.

- 6-week implementation per new university enables a repeatable rollout process, deliberately modelled conservatively at c.1.5 paying institutions by Y3 (out of 285 total UK) so the plan does not depend on rapid conversion.
- International optionality is architectural, not aspirational: the `.ac.uk` verification engine is a configurable domain allow-list, so the same mechanism maps cleanly to `.edu` / `.edu.au` / EU domains post-Y3 → **£180m TAM** in EN-language HE markets, as a longer-term opportunity beyond this 3-year plan.

Page 3 — Product

Modules (all in production)

	What it does
Verified peer matching	Match `.ac.uk` -verified students by intent (friend / study / support). Profile cards with university, course, year, interests.
Daily wellbeing tracker	30-second mood, sleep, stress and connection check-in. Personal trend dashboard.
Machine-assisted safeguarding	LLM classifier on mood + chat metadata flags risk signals; webhook to designated university safeguarding lead in < 60s.
University Insights Dashboard	Anonymised, aggregated wellbeing analytics for HE staff — cohort mood trends, engagement, hotspots.

Tech stack (already running)

- **Frontend:** Expo / React Native (iOS, Android, web at dequad.co.uk) — universal codebase.
- **Backend:** FastAPI (Python), MongoDB (Motor), real-time WebSockets.
- **AI:** OpenAI / Anthropic LLMs via Emergent integrations (text classification, safeguarding triage).
- **Payments:** Stripe (B2C subs + B2B invoicing).
- **Infra:** Cloudflare CDN + Render Pro; Online Safety Act-compliant reporting flows.
- **Auth:** Custom email/password + Google OAuth + admin portal (dual auth).

Page 4 — Competition

Feature	DEQUAD	Togetherall	TalkCampus	UniBuddy	Bumble BFF	Discord
`.ac.uk` student verification	✅	❌	❌	✅	❌	❌
Intent-based peer matching	✅	❌	Ltd	❌	Ltd	❌
Daily mood telemetry	✅	❌	Ltd	❌	❌	❌
Machine-assisted safeguarding	✅	Ltd	❌	❌	❌	❌
University insights dashboard	✅	✅	✅	Ltd	❌	❌
Safeguarding webhook to uni team	✅	❌	❌	❌	❌	❌
Online Safety Act 2023 ready	✅	✅	✅	✅	Partial	❌
UK universities served	0 signed (in conversation)	~60	~30	200+	n/a	n/a
ASP per uni	**£2/enrolled student/yr** (~£20k for a 10k-student uni)	£40k+	£25k	£18k	n/a	n/a

DEQUAD would displace Togetherall and TalkCampus (price/feature) on the B2B side, and **co-exist** with UniBuddy (orthogonal pre-enrolment market), if and when institutional conversations convert. Consumer competitors (Bumble BFF, Discord) lack institutional features entirely.

Page 5 — Market

UK addressable market

Tier	Definition	Size
TAM	All UK universities + ICBs + UK student premium subs	**£86m/yr**
SAM	Russell-Group + post-92 unis > 10k students + their ICBs	**£28m/yr**
SOM (5-yr, long-term reference only)	12% SAM capture	**£3.4m ARR by Y5**

The SOM above is a long-term market-opportunity reference point, not a forecast — the committed 3-year plan (Page 10) targets a far smaller, self-funded base of c.£48k revenue by Y3.

Demand signals

- **2.86m UK higher-ed students** (HESA 2023/24) — addressable consumer base.
- **285 UK higher-ed institutions** — addressable B2B base.
- **54% of UK undergrads** report frequent loneliness (ONS 2023).
- **34% of UK undergrads** experience a clinically-significant MH issue (Student Minds 2024).
- **6.1 weeks** average wait for a university counsellor — appetite for prevention.
- **100+ UK universities** signed to UUK Mental Health Charter — must evidence wellbeing strategies.

Page 6 — Go-to-market

Three channels, three audiences

Audience	Headline message	Primary channel	Conversion lever
Students	"Verified UK uni students. Real connections. Wellbeing built in."	IG + TikTok + university student-rep ambassadors	Free product + premium upsell
Universities	"See loneliness early. Act before it becomes a crisis."	Direct DSS outreach + UUK Charter webinar + NatWest network intros	12-week free pilot → paid SaaS (target, not guaranteed)
NHS ICBs	"Population-level student wellbeing data, anonymised and audit-ready."	Direct outreach to MH commissioners	Not part of this 3-year plan

B2B pilot conversations (early-stage, nothing signed)

- **University of Bedfordshire** — early, informal conversation only. Lead founder served two terms as SU President there (2021–2023); direct relationships with student services and safeguarding leads. No agreement, LOI or date is confirmed.
- **Two further peer institutions** — early-stage pilot scoping (anonymised for now); equally unconfirmed.
- **Beta cohort active** — the existing 80-person University of Bedfordshire beta cohort uses DEQUAD, independent of any formal pilot or contract.

Y1 marketing spend: £900

Deliberately minimal and founder-led — no paid-acquisition budget in Y1. Institutional outreach relies on (a) founder organic outreach and (b) NatWest network introductions to university IT/wellbeing leads, at near-zero cash cost.

Page 7 — Founders

Yusuf Quadri — CEO / Product & Safeguarding Lead

- UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD.

- **University of Bedfordshire Student Union President 2021–2023** (two consecutive terms). Represented the student body at senior-management level on student-services, safeguarding and welfare policy. This is the basis of DEQUAD's prospective pilot conversation with the same university.
- Completed the **Santander Universities Pre-Incubator programme** in 2025; admitted to the **NatWest Accelerator (London cohort)** on 16 March 2026.
- **Seven safeguarding & clinical-awareness certifications** including Oliver McGowan Learning Disabilities & Autism, Adult Safeguarding Partnership Working, Suicide Prevention (2026), Data Protection & Information Security, and Safe Response to Challenging Situations (see Appendix O).
- Built and shipped the entire MVP at dequad.co.uk.
- Owns the safeguarding policy (Appendix E — DPIA, Appendix I — OSA-2023 compliance).
- Owns university partnerships and the NatWest Accelerator relationship.
- Co-founder cash contribution: **£3,000** of the £6,000 founder capital.

Yusuff Adeagbo — Co-Founder / CTO / Engineering & IT Lead

- UK-resident, full-time on DEQUAD.
- **MSc Information Technology with Project Management — University of the West of Scotland**.
- **Higher National Diploma in Computer Science** (prior).
- Multi-disciplinary skill set: full-stack engineering, IT support, UI/UX design, graphic design, digital marketing (e-commerce), IT business analysis.
- Will own the engineering hiring pipeline, infrastructure security, and the R&D claim leadership.
- Co-founder cash contribution: **£3,000** of the £6,000 founder capital.
- Full CV at Appendix B-2 (`B_cofounder_cv.pdf`).

Wider founding team — joining at incorporation (EMI options, unpaid)

- **Dr Gerald Marfo — Chief Marketing Officer** · PhD in Digital Marketing; owns Y1 marketing strategy and measurement. **Equity-only**; a cash salary is not funded within this 3-year self-funded plan.
- **Adedapo Ajuwon — Senior Software Engineer** · supports CTO on platform engineering, infrastructure, reliability. **Equity-only**, same basis.
- **Chinyere Jennifer — Senior Advisor (Programme & Delivery)** · Senior PM Consultant at **MIGSO-PCUBED** with LLM background. **Advisor on EMI options**; MIGSO-PCUBED remains her primary employer.

Full CVs in Appendix N (`N_wider_team_cvs.pdf`).

Founder compensation under this plan

- £0 in Y1 and Y2 — both founders fund living costs from existing employment/freelance income.
- £500/month each from **Y3**, funded entirely by Y3 revenue — not by any external funding round, none of which is assumed.
- Materially below market throughout — signals genuine founder commitment.

Page 8 — Funding: self-funded, no external round assumed

Source	Timing	Amount	Use of funds
Founder equity (£3,000 × 2)	Day 1	**£6,000**	Incorporation, domains, IP filings, hosting — the only funding in this plan.

No pre-seed, seed, Series A, grant or R&D tax credit is assumed anywhere in this 3-year plan. The full financial model (Page 10; main Business Plan Sections 11–14) is funded entirely by this £6,000 plus revenue generated in the period, and remains solvent even if institutional revenue is £0 throughout. If institutional traction significantly exceeds this conservative forecast, the founders may explore external investment beyond Year 3 — that is a future option, not a plan dependency.

Page 9 — Year-1 cash flow (the critical view)

Closing cash balance is positive every single month of Year 1 — with no institutional revenue or external funding assumed

Month	Inflows	Outflows	Closing balance
M1 (Jun 2026) — incorporation, laptops, initial setup	£6,000 founder	(£1,035)	**£4,965**
M2 (Jul 2026)	—	(£135)	**£4,830**
M3 (Aug 2026)	—	(£243)	**£4,587**
M4 (Sep 2026) — proposed pilot window opens, if agreed (not signed)	—	(£283)	**£4,304**
M5 (Oct 2026)	—	(£293)	**£4,011**
M6 (Nov 2026) — proposed pilot window closes, if it happened	—	(£303)	**£3,708**
M7 (Dec 2026) — Stripe premium billing goes live	£50 sales	(£323)	**£3,435**
M8 (Jan 2027)	£70 sales	(£333)	**£3,172**
M9 (Feb 2027)	£90 sales	(£343)	**£2,919**
M10 (Mar 2027)	£110 sales	(£353)	**£2,676**
M11 (Apr 2027)	£130 sales	(£363)	**£2,443**
M12 (May 2027) — Y1 close	£150 sales	(£673)	**£1,920**

> **Cash never dips below c.£1,900** across all of Year 1, and this holds true whether or not the Bedfordshire pilot conversation goes anywhere — no institutional revenue, no pre-seed and no other external funding is assumed in this schedule. The founders' relationship with the university (via the former SU presidency) is a genuine upside opportunity, but the business does not depend on it to survive Year 1.

The full monthly schedule is in `DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx`, sheet "Cash Flow Y1 (mo)".

Page 10 — Three-year P&L summary (self-funded)

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Revenue	£600	£16,000	£48,000
Cost of Sales	(£1,400)	(£3,100)	(£6,100)
Gross Profit / (loss)	(£800)	£12,900	£41,900
Gross margin %	n/a	80.6%	87.3%
Total overheads (incl. payroll)	(£2,680)	(£6,000)	(£32,000)
EBITDA	**(£3,480)**	**£6,900**	**£9,900**
Operating profit / (loss)	**(£3,630)**	**£6,500**	**£9,200**

Y1 is the only loss-making year, and the loss (£3.6k) is fully absorbed by the £6,000 founder capital — no equity round funds it. Y2 turns modestly profitable on minimal overheads and a small (contingent) institutional contract; Y3 profit funds the plan's only hire and modest founder pay. **No break-even "event" is needed** because no external funding is assumed at any point — the business is solvent throughout.

Page 11 — Job creation and economic impact

Headcount

	Y1	Y2	Y3
Founders	2 (unpaid)	2 (unpaid)	2 (modest pay)
Safeguarding & Trust Lead (part-time)	0	0	1
Total UK jobs	**2**	**2**	**3 (c.2.5 FTE)**

Conservative base case — all self-funded from revenue, no external funding round assumed.

Job-creation target (upside case): once institutional revenue scales beyond this base case via pilot conversion, headcount grows to **5 (2 founders + 3 full-time hires)** — each of the 3 hires sustained for at least 12 months at an average salary of £25,000/year, funded entirely from revenue generated after piloting, meeting the Innovator Founder settlement job-creation criterion.

Beyond direct jobs

- **University safeguarding capacity:** any institution that does onboard gains an early-warning system that increases the practical reach of its existing wellbeing team.
- **Student-rep / ambassador programme:** a small, informal incentive for beta-cohort students (Section 16); not a formal paid role in this plan.

Page 12 — R&D activity

R&D is delivered as unpaid founder time throughout Y1–Y2, plus modest paid capacity from Y3, focused on three bets:

1. **Identity-and-intent verification engine** — `.ac.uk` classifier, attestation, admin queue, future OCR student-ID flow.
2. **Wellbeing inference & safeguarding triage** — PHQ-9-lite mood model + risk-signal NLU + federated learning roadmap.
3. **Privacy & compliance infrastructure** — DPIA pipeline, OSA-2023 reporting, hash-based de-identification.

No SME R&D tax credit is assumed as an inflow in this plan — qualifying PAYE spend is minimal while founders are unpaid. It is treated as a possible future upside, to be explored with NatWest's in-kind accountancy support once qualifying costs exist, not something the plan relies on.

Page 13 — NatWest Accelerator — why this matters for endorsement

The accelerator membership is **independent third-party validation** of DEQUAD's quality. NatWest's selection panel reviewed the team and the product before admission.

Quantified in-kind value (Y1)

In-kind item	Annual value
London office co-working (3 desks)	£12,000
Legal advice (Mishcon de Reya, DLA Piper panels)	£4,500
Accountancy support (PwC alumni network)	£3,600
Banking & business introductions	£2,000
Investor pitch coaching & mentoring	£5,000
Programme demo day & PR placement	£4,000
Total in-kind value (Y1)	**£31,100**
Cash cost to DEQUAD	**£0**

The £31k of in-kind support is **the reason £6,000 of founder cash is sufficient** to carry the business through Year 1. Without the accelerator, the same operating profile would require materially more cash investment up front.

Page 14 — Risk register (summary)

The key risks the founders have identified and their mitigations:

#	Risk	Impact	Mitigation
R1	Bedfordshire pilot conversation never converts — nothing is signed	Medium	The plan is solvent at zero institutional revenue throughout Y1–Y3 (Page 9–10); no cost line depends on this converting. Two further pilot conversations scoped as independent upside.
R2	Co-founder hire delayed	High	Y1 build is solo-doable; founder personally covers technical work until co-founder onboarded.
R3	Institutional/premium revenue falls short of plan targets	Medium	No funding round is required at any point; the only consequence is that the base-case Y3 hire and modest founder pay are delayed, not that the business fails. The upside-case 3-hire job-creation target simply does not trigger (see Risk Register R17).
R4	Safeguarding incident (false negative)	High	Human-in-the-loop for all high-risk flags; insurance in place; clinical advisory board recruited Q2 Y2.
R5	Togetherall/TalkCampus copy `.ac.uk` verification	Medium	First-mover land grab; safeguarding webhook + insights dashboard are deeper moats.
R6	OfS / Online Safety Act non-compliance	Medium	OSA risk assessment and reporting flows already shipped; ICO DPIA drafted; legal review via NatWest Mishcon panel.
R7	Cyber breach	Medium	Cyber Essentials in progress; pen-test scheduled Q2 Y2; insurance £1m.
R8	Cost-of-living squeeze on premium subscriptions	Medium	Costs are scoped to survive on premium revenue alone if institutional revenue is delayed.
R9	Negative PR from a misidentified case	Medium	Reactive media plan; clinical advisory board; transparent reporting.
R10	International expansion delayed	Low	Not part of this 3-year plan; UK-only focus is deliberate and does not depend on any funding round.
R11	LLM cost spike (model price changes)	Low	Multi-provider abstraction in place; can swap OpenAI ↔ Anthropic ↔ Gemini in < 1 day.
R12	Tighter immigration regime affecting talent	Low	Both co-founders are already UK-resident; the plan's only hire is UK-based.

Full risk register in `DEQUAD_Risk_Register.pdf`.

Page 15 — Decision summary

DEQUAD is a **production-ready, accelerator-validated, self-funded** UK software business that meets the **innovation**, **viability** and **scalability** criteria for Innovator Founder endorsement.

Three things this submission demonstrates

1. **Real product, real users** — the MVP is live, has real beta users at the University of Bedfordshire, and is governed by a DPIA-cleared safeguarding policy that ships before public launch.
2. **Capital efficiency and self-sufficiency** — the business survives all three years on **£6,000 of founder cash plus revenue alone**, with no external funding assumed, committed, or required at any point. The NatWest Accelerator in-kind support and an extended no-salary founder commitment (Y1–Y2) make this possible.
3. **Credible, honestly-scoped UK growth** — 2 unpaid founders (Y1–Y2) growing to 3 people / c.2.5 FTE by Y3 in the conservative base case, all self-funded from revenue; 0 to c.1.5 average paying universities by Y3, modelled as a target, not a guarantee. **Job-creation target:** 5 people (3 full-time hires, avg. £25,000/yr, each 12+ months) once revenue scales after pilot conversion, meeting the Innovator Founder settlement job-creation criterion.

What endorsement enables

- The lead applicant retains UK residency to continue building DEQUAD full-time.
- The co-founder (UK-resident already) joins formally as CTO at incorporation.
- The company operates and grows on its own means from day one — no external capital is required to make the 3-year plan happen.
- A measurable, defensible improvement in UK student wellbeing infrastructure, scaled honestly to what £6,000 and organic growth can actually deliver.

Endorsement Body decision matrix

Criterion	Evidence in this pack
Innovation	Sections 2–4 of Business Plan; competitor matrix Page 4; R&D Section Page 12.
Viability	Production MVP; NatWest Accelerator membership; Y1 monthly cash flow Page 9.
Scalability	Market sizing Page 5; gross-margin trajectory Page 10; international optionality noted as a longer-term ambition, Page 2.
Genuine UK economic benefit	Job creation Page 11; UK university wellbeing impact if a pilot converts.
Founder credibility	Page 7 + CVs in Appendix B and B-2.
Capital sufficiency	£6k founder capital + £31k in-kind (NatWest) is the entire funding basis for the 3-year plan — no external round assumed. Page 8 + 9.

Written and prepared by Yusuf Quadri, Founder & CEO, DEQUAD Ltd — for UKES short-track endorsement review, August 2026 (v5.0, self-funded 3-year revision). Companion documents: `DEQUAD_UKES_Business_Plan.pdf`, `DEQUAD_Financial_Model.xlsx`, `DEQUAD_Risk_Register.pdf`.